> the past . . . As a matter of principle, it were the Indians who brought about the demise of India . . . The character of the race is chaotic, their languages topsy turvy, their religions all separate from each other . . . there is no unified spirit, no patriotic thinking, the elites are drowning themselves in song and dance, and know nothing of great purpose . . . Alas, India is lost![21]

For some in China, among the causes of India's decline was Buddhism, with its metaphysical abstractions and non-violence. In 1937, Hu Shi, a Kuomintang ambassador to the US, in a speech at Harvard University's 300th anniversary, attributed China's lack of resistance to the Japanese to the 'Indianization of China' which had seeped into its culture thanks to Buddhism. As Wagner points out, he made these remarks even as the Kuomintang was trying to cultivate Indian nationalist support against the Japanese invasion.[22]

Wagner shows that news and analysis of India during this period was extensive. Between 1872 and 1938, *Shenbao*, a leading Chinese-language newspaper, published 1629 news and lead articles on India. A number of them were from Reuters, the British news agency. This amounted to an average of 24 per year or 2 per month. From 1921 to 1938, the average was 71 per year or nearly 6 articles per month. The Chinese-language periodical press, in addition, featured 9363 articles with the word 'India' in it. Initially, the reform press of Liang Qichao and Kang Youwei dominated India-related publishing. But after 1908, the more commercial press featured India materials. The average per year went up to 120 'dedicated articles' on India in the period until 1928 and then 540 articles per year thereafter.[23] This is quite extraordinary coverage and has probably never been repeated. Not all the coverage and commentary was negative: much of it may simply have been factual news of the day. Yet Wagner concludes, 'The increasingly rich and diverse knowledge about India available in China . . . was not able to undo the basic narrative of India being a country for the demise of which its own people were responsible . . . It had become a trope already by 1900, and it was revived time and again ever since.'[24]

It was in this context that Rabindranath Tagore visited China in 1924 after a trip to Japan. He was already famous for being the first Asian to get a Nobel Prize (in Literature) and arrived in China with his brand of non-